THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

Parkinson's law

Work expands to fill the time you give it

swipe →

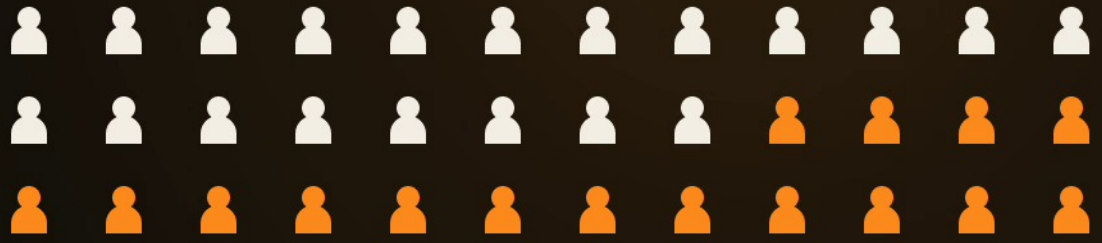
Ivan Rykov

Royal Navy, 1914 → 1928

Fewer ships
More officials



capital ships 20 −68%



Admiralty officials 3,569 +78%

1 figure = 100 officials · Parkinson's Law, 1957

“Work expands so as to fill the time available for its completion”

C. Northcote Parkinson

naval historian · The Economist, 1955

time available

the work

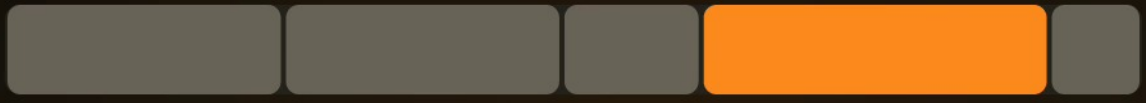
10 days

More time → the same work, slower

1 postcard
1 whole day

Parkinson's (satirical) example

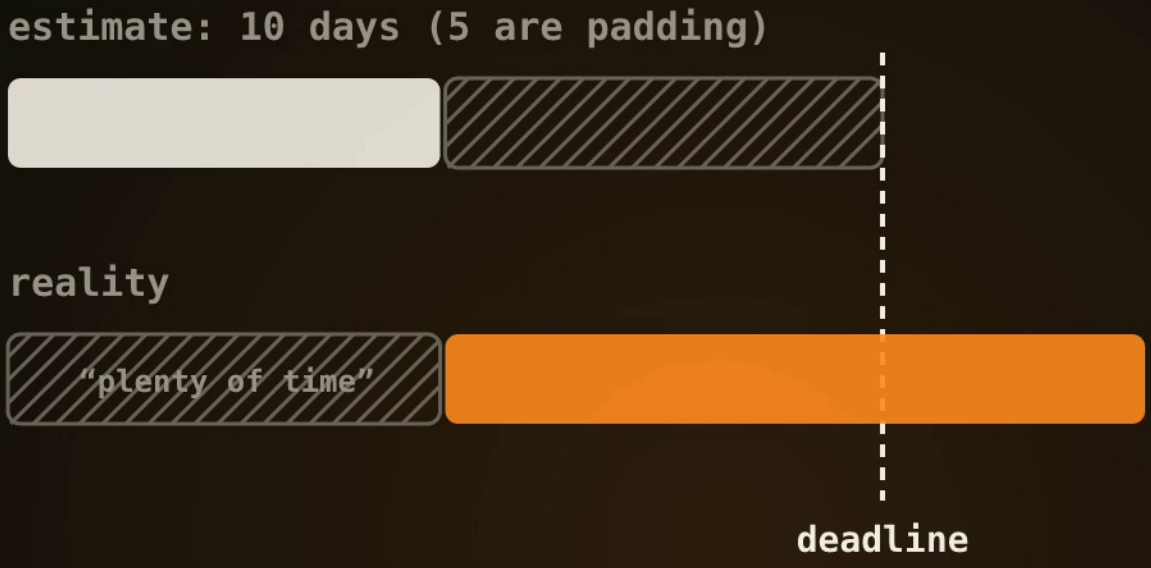
her day



1 h	find the postcard
1 h	find her glasses
30 min	find the address
1 h 15 min	write it
20 min	umbrella or not?

A busy person: 3 minutes

Padding doesn't survive contact



starts on day 5 → ships on day 13

Early finishes? Never reported

"Student syndrome" · Goldratt, Critical Chain, 1997 · illustration

Caught in the lab



speed on task 2

normal

told task 3 was cancelled

Less work ahead → slower now

Brannon, Hershberger & Brock, 1999 · bars illustrative

Fix the time
Flex the scope

6-week appetite



Cut features, not quality

Shape Up, Ryan Singer · Basecamp

But don't squeeze too hard



Fake deadlines → always late,
and a burned-out team

Estimates are already too short

Give work a box, not a blank check



WHAT I TAKE FROM THIS

In my teams, the date comes first, the scope is what we negotiate, and I never set fake deadlines. Large work goes in small slices, so we can ship, re-estimate and adjust early.

Sources: C. N. Parkinson, The Economist, 1955 · Parkinson's Law, 1957 · Brannon, Hershberger and Brock, 1999 · Goldratt, Critical Chain, 1997 · Shape Up, Basecamp

next: Hofstadter's law